4. Collateral Damage

We need 561 runs to win the first Test at the Gabba, with more than two days to play. Deep down, I know the game has long gone. But I go through my mental checklist, promise myself I will sell my wicket dearly. I will not let them grind me down. Then, just as I am about to walk out into the cauldron, I see something so personal, so painful and so profound that I'm shaken to the core.

Jonathan Trott, due to bat at number three, is putting his pads on across the dressing room. He has welled up until he is unable to stem the flood of tears. In any other environment I would retrace my steps and attempt to console a friend in distress. This is not the moment, nor the place, for instinctive compassion. Millions are waiting, unaware and ultimately uncaring.

There is a job to be done. This may appear heartless, when taken out of context, but I'm on autopilot. 'Sort that out, just sort it out,' I tell Andy Flower, our head coach. 'I've got to go out and bat. I don't care if he doesn't bat. You make that decision.' With that I go out with Michael Carberry, who is making his Ashes debut. I owe it to him to normalize abnormality.

Eighteen minutes later he is bowled by Ryan Harris, from the fourteenth ball he has faced: 560 runs to win, with nine wickets left. I look back and see Trotty walking towards me. It is only later that I will truly appreciate the poignancy of the moment, the moral courage it took for him to attempt an innings that bordered on self-sacrifice.